ISSUE 10

GALLIONS grapevine

December 2002

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

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Merry christmas

Welcome to our Christmas edition of Grapevine. This edition focuses on the many projects and initiatives that we are running in support of our vision for Thamesmead.

I would like to thank everybody who wrote to me with helpful comments and suggestions, not only for our services but for the Grapevine as well. Please keep your comments coming in via the feedback section on the back of this edition.

Finally, all of us at Gallions would like to wish you all a very happy Christmas and a prosperous New Year.

Bryan Richards
Email:brichards@gallionsha.co.uk



Residents help in choice of contractor

Right: Axis Chief Executive, John Hayes and Gallions Customer Services Director, Sue Chalkley celebrating our new partnership, with the new fleet of maintenance vehicles in the background

We are delighted to announce the appointment of our new response maintenance contractor Axis Europe PLC.

Axis has been appointed to do all day-to-day response maintenance and works to empty properties. They were appointed in July this year after a selection process that involved residents, staff and Board members. The contract started on 1st October 2002 and is for an initial period of 3 years. This could be extended depending on their performance and customer satisfaction.

We will be working with Axis as a Partnering contractor. This means we will be developing ways of workir together to provide the best possible service for our residents.

The main features of our contract with Axis:-

- Residents will have one contractor providing maintenance for all trades (except lift and CCTV maintenance).
- When your requests come in Axis will see details immediately through a direct link to our information technology system.
- Fixed arrangements for monitoring contract performance, with all jobs being completed by one contractor.
- Clearly identifiable contractors with Gallions Housing Association & Axis Europe PLC badges on vehicles and operatives.
- Agreed procedures on all working arrangements.
- Access for residents to meetings with Axis, using their resident liaison officer.

Axis will be running surgeries to get feedback from any resident who has views they would like to express on Axis' performance. These surgeries will take place at the Gallions Housing Association's office, in Harrow Manor Way. The times and dates of the surgeries are as follows:-

Wednesday 4th December 2002 – 4 pm – 6 pm
Wednesday 8th January 2003 – 10 am – 12 noon
Wednesday 5th February 2003 – 4 pm – 6 pm
Wednesday 5th March 2003 – 10 am – 12 noon

See **back page** for your list of contacts

Community Safety



Gallions staff, Neighbourhood Wardens and the various partners celebrating the launch of our new community safety partnership

Living Together

Recognising Thamesmead's multicultural and diverse community we are proud to announce that we have designed a strategy for our work with black and ethnic minority residents called 'Living Together'. This strategy is solidly endorsed by our Board, which has issued the following statement of commitment to this work:



"Gallions Housing Association is working to promote a welcoming, vibrant, confident and diverse community in Thamesmead where there is mutual respect for background, race, religion and culture."

Tokky Ademoyero, a Gallions Board member, chairs the Equality and Diversity panel that the Board has set up to ensure that the tasks laid out in the strategy are carried out.



Putting together the pieces for a safer environment

Our community safety team recently launched a new partnership with Bexley and Greenwich Councils and the Metropolitan Police Force called the Thamesmead, Abbey Wood and Plumstead Community Safety Partnership (TAPCSP)

We recognised the unique nature of Thamesmead, in that it straddles the two borough boundaries and saw this as an ideal opportunity to bring together the various organisations to help tackle local community safety and environmental issues across the Thamesmead, Abbey Wood and Plumstead areas.

We are actively developing a more structured approach to deal with people who cause nuisance to other residents or get involved in anti-social behaviour or criminal activity. Anyone who commits acts of this nature is likely to find themselves facing action.

Early successes include the securing of Government funding for new projects such as our successful Police on Bikes project and Neighbourhood Wardens scheme.

Neighbourhood Wardens Update

Our Neighbourhood Wardens are currently introducing themselves to the local community by attending youth clubs, local groups and projects. By doing this, they have been able to listen to the problems that residents are most concerned about.

Over the past 6 weeks they have spoken to about 160 local people during their patrols and visits. As a result of information given, our Neighbourhood Wardens have been involved in helping to resolve some anti-social behaviour issues. In one incident, they were able to deal with a youth who was behaving anti-socially. He was referred to one of the local youth schemes available in the area.

Contact our Neighbourhood Wardens office on 020 8320 3431 for more details.

We are here to help



Some homeowners are experiencing difficulties paying their leasehold service charges.

Here within Revenue Recovery, our specialist officer James Bell is able to discuss these difficulties with you. We can renegotiate a realistic repayment agreement that will enable you to clear any outstanding amounts owed to Gallions.

As you can appreciate we rely upon the income received from your payments to enable us to continue to deliver and provide communal services to you and other residents. These costs range from cleaning communal areas to providing communal lighting. Persistent non-payers will be put through the legal process and may face the threat of losing their homes. Leases provide for forfeiture when terms are breached.

We really do not wish things to progress to that stage so approach us now before it gets too late.

homeowner agony corner

" I am a lone parent with one child. I am a leaseholder having difficulty paying my service charges. When I became a leaseholder I could afford to pay my service charges as I was working. For the first time in my life I am now out of work after losing my job and am not sure whether I could get help with these costs. I am very worried about this.

Depending on your circumstances you may be able to apply for income based Job Seekers Allowance or possibly Income Support.

The Income Support and Job Seekers Allowance schemes allow for elements of service charge costs to be covered as part of the overall calculation for people satisfying the correct criteria. You would have to provide proof of the service charges by submitting a copy of your service charge statements with your application. The local benefit agency can provide you with the relevant forms to make the application for either of these benefits.

Depending upon when you first became a leaseholder it may also be possible to get help with your mortgage interest charges. This can become quite complicated as the law changed in 1995. Those whose mortgages were taken out before 1995 will be eligible for help much more quickly. Those who obtained mortgages after October 1995 would need to claim the cost from their mortgage protection policies.

If you are experiencing difficulties, you should contact the Welfare Benefits Officer at Gallions who is able to provide further advice and assistance on benefits payable to leaseholders for help with their service charges.

Education's End?

One School's fight for survival

Abbey Primary is the oldest school in Abbey Wood and Thamesmead. It has been the key point of many children's education for decades past and now there are proposals to close it.

The parents of the school's children have put together an action group to try and stop the school's closure. Parents, teachers and children have collected names on petitions, written letters to councillors and the Prime Minister.

Although Bexley Council have now given further thought to their decision, the closure order is still hanging over their heads and the school needs help.

If you have any views, comments or helpful advice for the school, please send your letters to:

Brenda Coleman
Abbey Primary
Lensbury way
Thamesmead
SE2 9TA

Customer Response Centre

update

Our Customer Response Centre continues to go from strength to strength. During October we received a total of 10,787 calls, and there were over 2,000 calls in the first week of November.

Now that the winter months are upon us we understand the problems you are likely to face and, despite the high volume of calls, we have improved our performance from 48% to well over 60% of calls answered within 15 seconds.

We are not complacent however, and will strive to improve our service to everyone we come into contact with.

Doreen Lawrence

Customer Response Centre Team Leader



Shared Ownership

We are building six 2 bedroom flats which will be available through a part buy, part rent scheme called Shared Ownership.

This is a scheme that helps people who can't afford to buy outright. You can buy half of the new home and pay a low rent on the rest. With Shared Ownership you can buy in easy stages until you own your home completely, or stay at the level that suits you best.

Our flats are in West Thamesmead and it is the first time we have done this type of scheme. We plan for them to be ready for occupation in March 2003. We expect to build more homes on this basis later in 2003 near Abbey Wood station and in Thamesmead Town Centre close to Safeways.

To apply for any of these schemes you will need to meet certain criteria. For example, you will need to be a current Council or Housing Association tenant or be on their waiting list for re-housing. There will also be minimum and maximum income limits set.

More information regarding the first scheme will be announced shortly.





Kevin impersonator larging it and having fun with some kids from our annual Housing Fayre

Thamesmead becomes the talk of the town

The theme of our annual Housing Fayre was 'Thamesmead in the Twenty-First Century'. Over 800 people called in throughout the day, which was packed with entertainment of all kinds. The event was organised by Gallions Residents Board (GRB) members and the Tenant Participation team. It was a great opportunity for Thamesmead's multi-cultural community to come together and meet Gallions people, as well as to find out about current and future projects such as Ecopark and the forthcoming regeneration of Tavy Bridge.

The GRB and Tenants Participation team would like to say thank you to everybody who turned up and contributed to the day. We are already planning next year's event so, if you have any ideas, please contact Jill McNiven or Linda Nash by email at jmcniven@gallionsha.co.uk or lnash@gallionsha.co.uk.

Thamesmead Vision Day

Renaisi, a consultancy that specialises in helping to regenerate areas, has been commissioned to carry out a community audit. The results will be used to help us with our strategy and guide the work of our Community Renewal Team.

This initiative was launched at our Housing Fayre and developed further in a Vision Day held on the 23rd October at the Woolwich Polytechnic. The Vision Day brought together Bexley and Greenwich Councillors, the Metropolitan Police, Chief Executives, community renewal professionals and the local community to draw on their knowledge and expertise within the community.

The aim of the Vision Day was to build and plan for the future. We also wanted to link ideas to potential action by thinking about Thamesmead in relation to the plans for the Thames Gateway and London as a whole. More information on this initiative will be announced shortly.

Contact Janet Poorman, Community Renewal Manager on 020 8320 3447 for more details.



Customer Feedback Panel

The Feedback Panel is a database of information held by the Tenant Participation Team, which enables us to talk to Gallions Tenants and Residents in a way the Tenants and Residents choose. At present we have more than 700 residents on the database.

You can ask to be consulted by any method you choose, from public meetings to face-to-face interviews in your home. You can even choose what you would like to give us your views on like Management and Maintenance of Gallions properties, Anti-Social Behaviour, Street Cleaning, in fact every thing that Gallions Housing Association do you can give your views on. You can also give your views on issues local to you or Thamesmead wide.

The information is stored and maintained by the TP Team only and is not used by anyone else, without permission from the named person.

If you are interested in being a part of the Customer Feedback Panel contact Linda Nash on 020 8320 3451, Jill McNiven on 020 8320 3417 or Linda Thompson on 020 8320 3468. You will then be sent a short questionnaire; the information you return will be added to the database.

Tenant Resource Centre

The Tenant Resource Centre is open to all Tenants and Charge-Payers of Gallions Housing. The centre has 7 computer workstations with internet access to enable you to write your own letters, newsletters, leaflets and posters. You can photocopy information, laminate posters, make labels etc.

There is a large conference room seating 20 people around a conference table, with additional space for a further 15 people. If necessary, the above can be used as cinema style seating for a capacity of approximately 45 seats There is a smaller meeting room seating 8 people around a conference table, with additional space for a further 3 people

Bookings can be made by contacting Linda Thompson on 020 8310 1500 Extn. 218 or 020 8320 3468

The Tenant Resource Centre is based at Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London, SE2 9XH Tel: 020 8310 1500 Extn. 218

tenant participation



Gallions Ecopark in Thamesmead

Ecopark

If you live in and around the Gallions Reach Urban Village you may have noticed a lot development and construction going on over the past few months. The development of our Ecopark has now been completed with the handover of 39 new homes in November.

Situated adjacent to Gallions Hill, the Ecopark scheme embraces the principle that cost effective affordable homes can be built using sustainable construction methods using environmentally friendly materials.

These homes do not use ground breaking eco-features, rather they have different combinations of practical, commonsense design solutions that are easy to use and maintain.

Some of the unique features included within the scheme are the use of sunrooms, solar collectors for pre-heating domestic water, underfloor heating, low temperature heating, individual gas condensing boilers, low flush toilets and water saving taps.

A Visitors' Centre has been built alongside a 'Naked House' providing visitors with an opportunity to gain a hands on experience, and a closer look at the environmentally sustainable features used throughout Ecopark. If you are interested in visiting Ecopark, or would simply like some further information, you can contact Rebecca Miller, the Visitors' Centre Manager on 020 8320 3435 or visit our website at www.gallionsecopark.co.uk

...involving our tenants

The London Borough of Greenwich, together with our Housing Co-ordinators, are currently putting nominations forward for Ecopark with prospective tenants being notified in the near future. To help our tenants settle into their new homes, we have set up 'meet your neighbour' sessions. These sessions will provide them with information about their new houses and how to get involved in focus groups and setting up tenants and residents associations.

Training and information on recycling, water and energy saving will be provided during the first few months of living in their new homes. If these sessions are successful we hope to be able to arrange further sessions in the future, which would be available to anyone who wanted to come along.

If you are interested in receiving training about recycling, water and energy saving, please contact Sam Weaver on 020 8320 3418



an hour of your time...

could make a lifetime's difference...

Could you help a child to read?
Or help to develop their numeracy skills?
We are looking for some volunteers!

An hour or two of your time for a few weeks could make a lasting difference to a child

- Good reading and numeracy skills open the door to quicker and easier learning.
- Children can benefit from having a friendly adult to give them encouragement, boost their self-confidence and help them improve their skills.
- Helping children can be very enjoyable and rewarding.
- A short training session for volunteers will be provided.

If you have some spare time each week and would like to help in a local school near you, please contact:

Debbie Withall

Tel:020 8320 3480

Fax:020 8370 0781

Email: dwithall@gallionsha.co.uk

drama workshop

The community chest is now up and running and is already helping to support local initiatives such as the Theatre School Drama workshop that was run during the autumn school break.

Local children had the opportunity to attend the workshop and get involved in song, dance and drama as well as learning new performing skills and developing basic theatrical techniques.

If you are interested in applying to the community chest to fund a local initiative please contact Kaye Sene on 020 8320 3462 or via email at ksene@gallionsha.co.uk

audio x

- Create your own CD quality beats and burn onto CD
- Gain a qualification on a 12 week course
- Drop-in &Workshop sessions
- Advice &information about careers &training
- Links with the music industry from absolute beginner to advanced

Audio X
@The Audio Lounge, YAP
c/o Gallions
Harrow Manorway
Thamesmead
London
SE2 9XH
Tyap @in-volve.org.uk

For booking details call the Audio X Team on:
020 8311 5111

Greenwich on track

As you may already be aware, an exciting project designed to support families with children, is up and running in your area! ON TRACK is a Children's Fund Initiative, which was originally set up by the Home Office. The project has been operating in Thamesmead for one year, supporting parents and children from Heronsgate, Linton Mead and Windrush schools. We are currently in a very exciting position, have a new staff team and are working hard to improve the services we offer.

Parent/children could benefit from the following On Track services:

- **Speech & Language therapy**
- **Parent/carer advice and support**
- **Support in transfer to secondary school**
- **Educational Psychology**
- **Parent education/employment courses**
- **Other community resources**

We have a Link Worker who visits our three schools on one day each week and have recently recruited a Community Link Worker who is hoping to engage with local people and offer further support to parents/carers.

We are particularly interested in running workshops and courses for parents and would welcome any ideas or suggestions you have. We would also like to hear from any existing community groups or local services who may be able to provide us with space for surgeries or who feel they could link with ON TRACK in another way.

If you already have a child at one of these schools, have a youngster of pre-school age, whom you are intending to send to one, or live in the local area and would be interested in possible volunteering positions within ON TRACK, then please give us a call on 020 8317 1701. Our office is situated above Heronsgate School and is open from 9am-5pm Monday-Friday.

We look forward to hearing from you soon,

Sandra, Natalie, Karen and Wendy

(Your New On-Track Team)



Pay as you go insurance still available to you

Last year we launched a low cost Home Contents Insurance Scheme for all Gallions residents in response to problems that residents had experienced in getting affordable cover. The scheme is very different from the usual type of policy you may have looked at before:

- All residents are guaranteed cover wherever they live
- There is no requirement to have special locks or security devices
- There is no 12 month contract, the cover is "pay as you go" just like a mobile phone
- You pay in cash at the post office fortnightly or monthly by direct debit.

how much?

Sum Insured	Fortnightly at the Post Office	Monthly by Direct Debit	Annually by credit/debit card
£6,000.00	£2.23	£3.64	£43.68
£7,000.00	£2.51	£4.25	£50.96
£8,000.00	£2.79	£4.85	£58.24
£9,000.00	£3.07	£5.46	£65.52
£10,000.00	£3.35	£6.07	£72.80
£11,000.00	£3.63	£6.67	£80.08
£12,000.00	£3.91	£7.28	£87.36
£13,000.00	£4.19	£7.89	£94.64
£14,000.00	£4.47	£8.49	£101.92
£15,000.00	£4.75	£9.10	£109.20
£16,000.00	£5.03	£9.71	£116.48
£17,000.00	£5.31	£10.31	£123.76
£18,000.00	£5.59	£10.92	£131.04
£19,000.00	£5.87	£11.53	£138.32
£20,000.00	£6.15	£12.13	£145.60
£21,000.00	£6.43	£12.74	£152.88

frequently asked questions

Q I don't need insurance Gallions cover my property.

A Gallions do not insure your personal property, this is your responsibility

Q I live in a high-risk post code, insurers won't cover me.

A This scheme is open to all Gallions residents wherever you live

Q What locks to I need to get this insurance?

A There are no security conditions required, you are automatically eligible for cover

Q I don't want to pay by direct debit through the bank?

A You can pay fortnightly by cash at your local Post Office or annually by cheque or card.

Q What happens if I can't keep up my payments or wish to leave the scheme.

A There is no minimum time that you have to be in the scheme as it is a "PAY AS YOU GO" insurance, you leave at any time and there are no penalties.

Gallions Housing Association will not profit financially from this scheme.

FALSE ENCOMOMY!

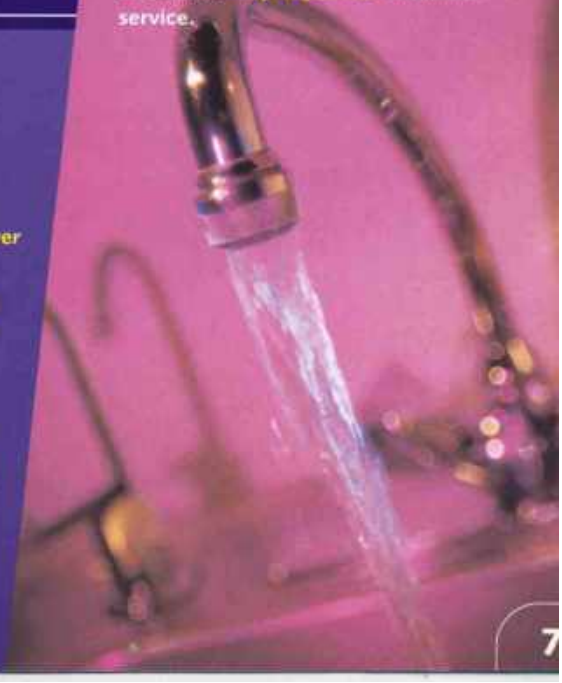
Below is a real life story of one our residents who decided that they didn't need home contents insurance, a decision which ended up costing them £500 when they could have been insured for a whole year for as little as £43.68!

"looking forward to a nice long soak in the bath, one of our tower block tenants put the plug in the bath and turned the taps on, at which point the telephone rang. Caught up in a conversation on the telephone the filling bath went out of his mind, until he heard a strange gushing sound coming from the direction of the bathroom.

He ran to the bathroom turned off the taps and pulled the bath plug out, but it was too late, his bathroom was flooded and so were two of the flats on the floors below.

This lapse in concentration cost the tenant almost £500 in total, for a Gallions contractor to attend 'Out of Hours' to take up the excess water and repair the flood damage to the decorations in his neighbours flat.

This unforeseen expenditure could have been avoided if he had taken advantage of Gallions "Pay as you Go" insurance service.



Gallions Board News

It has been a busy time for the Gallions Board over the last months. During September and October the Board held its Annual General Meeting, two further Board meetings, an annual Strategic Planning Day and a Board Training Weekend. There have been various changes to membership and the Board now comprises:

Residents	*Independents*	*Local Authority Nominees*
Tokky Ademoyero	Ronke Ademoyero	Manny Blake
Freda McKewen	William Ekinu	Harbans Buttar
Graham Horton	Chris Garlick	Peter Kotz
Ken Sealey	Keith Wrate	John Wakefield

Various appointments have been made by the Board and these include:

Chair	Graham Horton
Treasurer	Ronke Adeagbo
Secretary	Averyl Richards

Board members have been appointed to champion various areas:

● *Change*	Graham Horton
● *Development*	Keith Wrate
● *Equality*	Tokky Ademoyero
● *Probity*	Graham Horton
● *Public Relations*	Chris Garlick

At the strategic planning day the Board looked at plans for Gallions over the coming years and agreed its vision, mission and values. These will be published in the new year in the Gallions Business Plan.

Team building was the theme for the Board Training Weekend in October. It was an exhausting but enjoyable weekend with the Board and Executive Team members giving up their free time to take part.

The dates for the next Board meetings are 12 December 2002 and 20 March 2003. All meetings are open to residents and are held at Gallions offices at 7pm. If you are interested in attending please let Averyl Richards know on 020 8320 3410 or email her at arichards@gallionsha.co.uk

Feedback

We welcome your suggestions and constructive comments on how we can improve our services and make your environment and home a better place to live in. Simply send your comments to:-
Feedback, Gallions Grapevine, Bryan Richards, Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH.

Don't forget to add your name, address and telephone number for contact details or alternatively email me on brichards@gallionsha.co.uk

Sheltered bedsits

We will soon have a number of sheltered bedsits available for letting in the Crossways area of Thamesmead. They have the benefit of a part time warden and communal facilities.
If you are interested in applying for one of these homes you must:
● be of pensionable age and
● already live in Thamesmead or have a connection with it.

For more information please contact the re-housing team on 020 8320 3408/3405

Good news on empty homes

Rent loss:
April–Aug 01 = £88,918
April–Aug 02 = £66,014
This is a reduction of £22,904

Re-let times have also reduced:
April–Aug 01 = 4.48 weeks
April–Aug 02 = 3.19 weeks

Warning to owners of untaxed cars

Tenants and residents who park untaxed motor vehicles on Gallions land are in breach of their tenancy agreement and Gallions has given the relevant agencies permission to remove such cars.

Contact us

Gallions Housing Association
Harrow Manor Way
London SE2 9XH
Customer Response Centre
Freephone
0800 83 84 81

This freephone number is now taking all calls to Gallions via the Customer Response Centre, this also includes switchboard calls.

The old switchboard number will be withdrawn in the coming months.

ਜੇ ਅੰਗਰੇਜ਼ੀ ਤੁਹਾਡੀ ਪਹਿਲੀ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਨਹੀਂ, ਅਤੇ ਤੁਸੀਂ ਇਸ ਦਸਤਾਵੇਜ਼ ਦਾ ਤਰਜਮਾ ਚਾਹੁੰਦੇ ਹੋ, ਤਾਂ ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ ਆਪਣੀ ਜੁਦੀ ਹੋਈ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਦੇ ਨਾਂ ਦੇ ਨੇੜੇ ਵਾਲੇ ਖ਼ਾਨੇ ਵਿਚ ਸਹੀ ਦਾ ਨਿਸ਼ਾਨ ਲਾ ਕੇ, ਅਤੇ ਦੱਸੀ ਹੋਈ ਥਾਂ 'ਤੇ ਆਪਣਾ ਨਾਂ ਅਤੇ ਪਤਾ ਲਿਖ ਕੇ ਇਹ ਫ਼ਾਰਮ ਕਿਸੇ ਲਿਫ਼ਾਫ਼ੇ ਵਿਚ ਪਾ ਕੇ ਹੇਠ ਲਿਖੇ ਪਤੇ 'ਤੇ ਭੇਜ ਦਿਓ।

如果英語不是您的母語，您希望將該文件翻譯出來的話，請在您選擇的語言旁邊打勾，請在所示之處填上您的姓名和地址，併用信封將本表格寄到下列地址。

Nếu Anh ngữ không phải là ngôn ngữ chính, Quý vị muốn dịch tài liệu nầy, xin vui lòng đánh dấu vào ô kế bên ngôn ngữ Quý vị chọn, ghi tên và địa chỉ vào nơi chỉ dẫn và gởi mẫu vào phong bì theo địa chỉ dưới đây.

PUNJABI ☐ **CHINESE** ☐ **VIETNAMESE** ☐ *(please tick one)*

Name: .....

Address: .....

.....

Return to: Bryan Richards (Translation Requests), Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH